Finland: trust or control?

> **Finland trains its teachers for years and does not inspect its schools. Then its results began to fall. This dossier gives you the facts, four voices and a debate.**

Name _____ **Date** _____

This is your page for the lesson. The numbers and titles match the lesson on the screen, so you can follow along. Write here, circle here. The answers are in the lesson, not on this page. A dotted word has a translation on the screen.

1 START HERE

Funding or trust?

Supporters of more funding say the numbers are clear: a country cannot fix what it does not pay for. Others look at Finland. To teach in a Finnish basic or secondary school, you need a master's degree. The country has no classroom inspectors, and principals guide teachers through trust rather than control.

Words from the text

funding
financiamento, verba

inspectors
fiscais, inspetores

principals
diretores de escola

Talk about these first

Then read the documents.

1 **Who should decide how a teacher teaches: the teacher, the school or the government?**

_____

_____

2 **Do schools get better when they receive more money? Why or why not?**

_____

_____

3 **How do you feel when someone checks your work? Does it help you or stress you?**

_____

_____

A DOCUMENT A · FINLAND

The Model

By EIC Magazine · 1 min read

For decades, Finland was the country that other governments visited when they wanted to understand good schools. A delegation of teachers and politicians traveled to Helsinki to find out what was different.

The first thing they noticed was who stood in front of the class. To teach in a Finnish basic or secondary school, you need a master's degree. A subject teacher also needs at least 60 credits of pedagogical study: training in how to teach, not only in what to teach. Since the 1970s, this training has taken place in universities.

The second thing was what was missing. Finland has no system of school inspections. Nobody from outside visits classrooms to check that teachers are doing their job. Central control of textbooks ended in 1992, so teachers have wide freedom to choose their methods and materials. Even head teachers traditionally do not visit lessons to evaluate individual teachers.

Supporters of the model say the logic is simple: if you select and train teachers carefully, you do not need to watch them constantly. Parents trust the schools, so there is no need for control just for control's sake. According to a 2014 World Economic Forum article, Finland did not even spend an especially large share of its budget on education compared with other OECD countries.

In this reading, trust came first, built through years of teacher education. Only then could control be reduced.

Sources: Silicon Canals, Finland trusted education; World Economic Forum, Why are Finland's schools so good? (2014); Stanford, The Secret to Finland's Success: Educating Teachers.

Words from the text

credits
créditos (de disciplina)

delegation
comitiva, delegação

evaluate
avaliar o desempenho

head teachers
diretores de escola

inspections
inspeções, fiscalização externa

OECD
OCDE

pedagogical
pedagógico, relativo ao ensino

1 Choose the best answer.

Choose one answer.

EXAMPLE

Where is Finland?

A) In Northern Europe · B) In South America · C) In Africa

A

1 What did visitors notice first about Finnish classrooms?

- ○ **A** Small classes
- ○ **B** The teachers' level of education
- ○ **C** The use of tablets
- ○ **D** A longer school day

2 What ended in 1992?

- ○ **A** Compulsory exams
- ○ **B** Private schools
- ○ **C** Long holidays
- ○ **D** Central control of textbooks

3 Besides a master's degree, what does a subject teacher need?

- ○ **A** 60 credits of pedagogical study
- ○ **B** Ten years of experience
- ○ **C** A government license exam
- ○ **D** A second language

4 Why do supporters say inspections are unnecessary?

- ○ **A** The country is too small
- ○ **B** Inspectors are too expensive
- ○ **C** Careful selection and training make constant watching unnecessary
- ○ **D** Parents refused them

5 Which sentence best summarizes the last paragraph?

- ○ **A** Finland removed control and trust appeared
- ○ **B** Trust was built first through teacher education, then control could be reduced
- ○ **C** Finland has no school system at all
- ○ **D** Teachers are trusted because they earn more

2 True or false?

Is the sentence true or false, according to the text?

EXAMPLE "Finland is a country in Europe."
True

1 "Finnish teachers only need a bachelor's degree."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

2 "Teacher education moved to universities in the 1970s."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

3 "Finland has no system of school inspections."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

4 "Textbooks are still approved centrally."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

5 "Teachers largely choose their own methods and materials."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

6 "The text says Finland spends far more on education than other OECD countries."

○ True ○ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

3 Find in the text a word or phrase that means:

Write the word or phrase from the text in the space.

EXAMPLE A place where children learn = **school**

1 A group of officials sent to visit a place = _____

2 To check how well someone does their work = _____

3 Checks on a school by people from outside = _____

4 A unit that measures university study = _____

4 Write 2 to 3 sentences.

EXAMPLE I think schools need more music because it helps students relax.

YOUR TURN

1. Why might trust reduce the need for inspections?

2. Could a school system without inspections work in Brazil? Why or why not?

B DOCUMENT B · FINLAND

The Crack

By EIC Magazine · 1 min read

Finland's fame began with a test. PISA, run by the OECD, measures what 15-year-olds can do in reading, math and science. Finland took part for the first time in 2000, and its early results made the country a model for the world.

The latest round tells a more complicated story. In 2022, Finnish students scored 484 points in math, against an OECD average of 472. In reading they scored 490, against 476. Both results are still above average. But in reading the score fell by 30 points compared with 2018, and the fall was steeper than the OECD average. Math has been going down since 2006. There are now more weak performers in math and fewer top ones, and the gap between schools has grown somewhat.

Finland was not alone: scores fell in most countries in 2022, a round that took place after the pandemic. But Finland's decline began long before that, which is why the debate matters.

Nobody agrees on the cause. Some critics blame pupil-led methods, which give students more control and less structure. Others point to digital tools in the classroom, and a 2018 study linked them to lower results in math and science. Defenders of the model answer that no single cause has been proved, and that the data do not show that trust itself failed.

Sources: Ministry of Education and Culture of Finland, PISA 2022 (5 Dec 2023); OECD, PISA 2022 Results, Country Notes: Finland; Secondary sources for the debate on causes (see teacher notes).

Words from the text

blame
culpar

gap
diferença, distância entre grupos

OECD
OCDE

PISA
PISA, teste internacional de jovens de 15 anos

pupil-led methods
métodos centrados no aluno

steeper
mais acentuado

structure
estrutura, organização

weak performers
alunos com resultados baixos

5 Choose the best answer.

Choose one answer.

1 What does PISA measure?

- ○ **A** Teachers' salaries
- ○ **B** School budgets
- ○ **C** How many students finish school
- ○ **D** What 15-year-olds can do in reading, math and science

2 What was Finland's reading score in 2022?

- ○ **A** 490, above the OECD average
- ○ **B** 476, below the OECD average
- ○ **C** 484, equal to the OECD average
- ○ **D** 472, below the OECD average

3 What is true about Finland's decline?

- ○ **A** It began after the pandemic
- ○ **B** It affected only math
- ○ **C** It began long before the pandemic and was steeper than the OECD average in reading
- ○ **D** Reading scores stayed stable

4 **Which gap has grown somewhat?**

- ◯ **A** Between boys and girls
- ◯ **B** Between schools
- ◯ **C** Between Finland and Sweden
- ◯ **D** Between teachers' salaries

5 **What do defenders of the model say?**

- ◯ **A** Trust failed, so inspections should return
- ◯ **B** The test is useless
- ◯ **C** The decline is exaggerated
- ◯ **D** No single cause has been proved, and the data do not show that trust failed

6 True or false?

Is the sentence true or false, according to the text?

1 **"Finland's 2022 scores were still above the OECD average."**

◯ **True** ◯ **False**

If false, write the correct fact: _____

2 **"Only Finland's scores fell in 2022."**

◯ **True** ◯ **False**

If false, write the correct fact: _____

3 **"Math scores have been falling only since 2022."**

◯ **True** ◯ **False**

If false, write the correct fact: _____

4 **"The gap between schools has grown somewhat."**

◯ **True** ◯ **False**

If false, write the correct fact: _____

5 **"Everyone agrees on why Finland's results fell."**

◯ **True** ◯ **False**

If false, write the correct fact: _____

6 **"Finland first took part in PISA in 2000."**

◯ **True** ◯ **False**

If false, write the correct fact: _____

7 Find in the text a word or phrase that means:

Write the word or phrase from the text in the space.

1 **Faster and bigger (a fall) =** _____

2 **Students with low results =** _____

3 **To say that someone or something is responsible for a problem =** _____

4 **Methods in which students have more control =** _____

8 Think critically.

YOUR TURN

Someone says: “Finland stopped inspecting schools, and later its scores fell. So inspections would fix the problem.” Does the timing prove this? Write 2 to 3 sentences.

9 Write 2 to 3 sentences.

YOUR TURN

Which explanation seems more convincing to you, pupil-led methods or digital tools? Why?

C DOCUMENT C · FINLAND

The Response

By EIC Magazine · 1 min read

In August 2025, a new rule came into force in Finnish schools. Under an amendment to the Basic Education Act, which Parliament passed in April, pupils aged seven to 16 may not use mobile phones during lessons. The exceptions are narrow: a teacher can allow a phone for learning, as a study aid, or for health reasons. If a phone disrupts teaching, a teacher or principal can confiscate it.

The law sets a minimum, and schools decide the rest. At one school in Varkaus, about 700 pupils keep their phones in their bags or in lockers all day, even at recess. In Tampere, pupils may use phones during breaks, but only outside the building. The National Agency for Education wants stricter rules than the law requires, including no phones at mealtimes.

The government explained the reform by pointing to results. The education minister said that reading and math skills had deteriorated, and that Finland wanted to create more space for learning and teaching. He added that schools were not leaving the digital world.

Reactions were mixed. One principal said the change had exceeded expectations. Some pupils agreed that phones are a distraction. Others said the law showed a lack of trust in them, a striking idea in a country whose school system was built on trust.

It is too early to know whether the law will improve results. For now, it raises an old question in a new form: when should a school trust, and when should it set limits?

Sources: AFP via The Peninsula, Finnish students to return to mobile-free classrooms (1 Aug 2025); Euronews / AP, Finland to restrict smartphones in school (1 May 2025); Yle, Government plan to ban phones in classrooms; The Star, Ring the bell, not the phone (18 Sep 2025).

Words from the text

amendment
emenda, alteração de uma lei

come into force
entrar em vigor

confiscate
confiscar

deteriorated
piorou

disrupt
atrapalhar, interromper

exceeded expectations
foi melhor do que se esperava

lockers
armários individuais

pupils
alunos

recess
recreio

striking
surpreendente, que chama a atenção

10 Choose the best answer.

Choose one answer.

1 When did the law come into force?

- ○ **A** April 2025
- ○ **B** June 2023
- ○ **C** August 2025
- ○ **D** January 2026

2 When can a pupil use a phone in class?

- ○ **A** Only with the teacher's permission, for learning or health reasons
- ○ **B** Whenever the lesson is boring
- ○ **C** Only at recess
- ○ **D** Never, with no exceptions

3 What does the law leave to each school?

- ◯ **A** Whether phones exist
- ◯ **B** Teachers' salaries
- ◯ **C** Exam dates
- ◯ **D** The rules for other parts of the school day

4 Why did the government say it wanted the law?

- ◯ **A** To save money on equipment
- ◯ **B** Reading and math skills had deteriorated, so it wanted more space for learning
- ◯ **C** To stop schools using computers
- ◯ **D** Because parents asked for new exams

5 What idea do some pupils express?

- ◯ **A** Phones should be allowed everywhere
- ◯ **B** The law is too soft
- ◯ **C** The law shows a lack of trust in them
- ◯ **D** Teachers should be inspected

11 True or false?

Is the sentence true or false, according to the text?

1 "The law applies to pupils aged seven to 16."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

2 "Phones are completely banned for the whole school day in every school."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

3 "Teachers cannot take a phone away, even when it disrupts a lesson."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

4 "Schools can choose different rules for breaks."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

5 "The National Agency for Education wants stricter rules than the law requires."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

6 "The text proves that the law has improved Finland's PISA results."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

12 Find in the text a word or phrase that means:

Write the word or phrase from the text in the space.

1 To take a phone away from a pupil = _____

2 Became worse = _____

3 Small cupboards where pupils keep their things = _____

4 To interrupt a lesson or cause a problem for it = _____

13 Take a position.

YOUR TURN

Is a phone rule in school a sign of distrust or a way to support learning? Write 3 sentences.

14 Connect the documents.

YOUR TURN

How does this law fit, or not fit, the idea that Finland's system is built on trust? Write 2 to 3 sentences.

D DOCUMENT D · VOICES

Voices

These four people are invented. Their words are not real quotes. Each one stands for a position that is common in the debate.

Marja Koskinen · 47, math teacher in Tampere

I have taught for twenty years, and nobody has ever sat at the back of my classroom to grade me. People hear that and think we are left alone. We are not. We plan together, and we talk about every pupil who is struggling. Inspectors would bring paperwork, not insight. The phone rule? I use it, and pupils concentrate better. But I would never want the state to tell me how to teach fractions.

Tuomas Lehtonen · 55, education researcher in Helsinki

I admire what Finland built, but admiration is not evidence. Reading scores have been falling for years, and a system that cannot explain why has a problem. Trust is fine when outcomes are good. When they fall, you need independent data, from outside the school, to see where help is needed. Calling that 'control' is a convenient way to avoid the question.

Aino Virtanen · 16, high school student

Honestly, the phone rule annoys me. I use my phone to check words and my timetable, and now I have to ask permission. It feels like adults think we cannot be responsible. But I admit I pay more attention in class now, and at lunch my friends talk to each other instead of looking at screens. So I am confused.

Jari Nieminen · 43, father of two students, Espoo

The phone law is the first thing in years that made me feel the system was listening to parents. What worries me is something else: schools in our city are very different, and I have no easy way to compare them. I want to trust my children's teachers, but I would also like clear information about how the school is doing.

Words from the text

annoys
irrita, incomoda

convenient
cômodo, conveniente

evidence
evidência, prova

grade
dar nota, avaliar

insight
compreensão profunda

outcomes
resultados

paperwork
burocracia, papelada

struggling
com dificuldade

timetable
horário de aulas

15 Who says it?

Read Document D again. Then choose Marja, Tuomas, Aino or Jari.

EXAMPLE "I teach math in Tampere."
Marja

1 "Independent data should show where help is needed."
○ Marja ○ Tuomas ○ Aino ○ Jari

2 "The rule makes me feel adults do not trust students."
○ Marja ○ Tuomas ○ Aino ○ Jari

3 "Inspectors would bring paperwork, not insight."
○ Marja ○ Tuomas ○ Aino ○ Jari

4 "I would like clearer information about how schools compare."
○ Marja ○ Tuomas ○ Aino ○ Jari

5 "Teachers already discuss struggling pupils together."
○ Marja ○ Tuomas ○ Aino ○ Jari

6 **“I concentrate better, even though I dislike the rule.”**

◯ Marja ◯ Tuomas ◯ Aino ◯ Jari

16 Choose the best answer.

Choose one answer.

1 **What does Marja say about working without inspections?**

◯ **A** Teachers work alone and nobody helps them
◯ **B** Principals visit weekly
◯ **C** Teachers plan together and discuss struggling pupils
◯ **D** Parents inspect instead

2 **What is Tuomas’s main worry?**

◯ **A** Falling results without independent data to explain them
◯ **B** Phones in class
◯ **C** Teacher salaries
◯ **D** Too many exams

3 **Why is Aino confused?**

◯ **A** She wants more homework
◯ **B** She dislikes the rule but notices a benefit
◯ **C** She thinks phones are never useful
◯ **D** She wants stricter rules

4 **What does Jari want?**

◯ **A** Phones everywhere
◯ **B** Inspections of teachers
◯ **C** Better-trained teachers
◯ **D** To trust teachers but also get clearer information about schools

17 True or false?

Is the sentence true or false, according to the text?

1 **“Aino says the phone rule has no effect on her.”**

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

2 **“Tuomas thinks trust is always enough.”**

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

3 **“Marja has been teaching for about twenty years.”**

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

4 **“Jari feels the phone law shows the system listening to parents.”**

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

5 **“Marja wants more national inspections.”**

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

6 **“Jari says schools in his city are very different.”**

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact: _____

18 Complete the sentences.

EXAMPLE Aino says she ____ because ____. She dislikes the rule because she must ask permission.

YOUR TURN

1. Marja believes inspections would ____ because ____.

2. Tuomas wants ____ because ____.

19 Debate preparation.

YOUR TURN

Choose a side: "A school system can rely on trust alone." Write two reasons and one answer to the opposite side. Use at least one of these chunks: I see your point, but… · That depends on… · What worries me is…

E DOCUMENT E · DEBATE

Trust or control?

THE MOTION

A school system can rely on trust more than on control.

ONE GROUP DEFENDS

Trust

Schools work best when teachers are trusted to decide how to teach.

THE OTHER GROUP DEFENDS

Control

Schools need outside checks and data, such as inspections and tests.

How the debate works

1	**Sides**	One group defends Trust. The other defends Control. The sides are drawn by lot, so nobody defends only what they already think, and the debate is fair.	2 min
2	**Preparation**	Each group chooses 3 facts from the Evidence Bank and writes a claim.	8 min
3	**Round 1**	Each side presents its main argument. No interruptions.	2 min per side
4	**Round 2**	Each side answers the other side's argument. This is the rebuttal.	2 min per side
5	**Closing**	Each side sums up in 3 sentences.	1 min per side
6	**Verdict**	The observers give their verdict: which side was more convincing, and why?	3 min

One-to-one class: the teacher takes the side opposite to the student's. The Evidence Bank is the same.

Evidence Bank

WHERE	FACT
Document A	Finnish teachers need a master's degree.
Document A	Finland has no system of school inspections.
Document B	Reading scores fell by 30 points between 2018 and 2022.
Document B	Scores fell in most OECD countries in 2022, not only in Finland.
Document B	The gap between schools has grown somewhat.
Document C	A national law now limits phones in class, and schools decide the rest.
Document C	Some pupils say the phone law shows a lack of trust in them.

Language chunks

USE	SAY
Claim	Our main point is that… · We believe that…
Evidence	The data show that… · According to the text…
Rebuttal	I see your point, but… · That depends on… · That does not prove that…
Concession	It is true that…, but…
Closing	To sum up… · What worries me is…

A concession admits that the other side is right about one point, and then goes on with your own argument.

Words from the text

by lot
por sorteio

claim
afirmação principal

fair
justo

motion
a moção, a frase em debate

rebuttal
contra-argumento

verdict
veredito

20 Which side would use this fact first? Choose Trust or Control.

Trust says teachers should decide. Control says outside checks and data matter.

EXAMPLE Teachers in Finland have wide freedom to choose their methods.
Trust

1 Reading scores fell by 30 points between 2018 and 2022.

○ Trust ○ Control

2 Teachers need a master's degree.

○ Trust ○ Control

3 Scores fell in most OECD countries in 2022.

○ Trust ○ Control

4 The gap between schools has grown somewhat.

○ Trust ○ Control

5 A national law now limits phones in classrooms.

○ Trust ○ Control

6 Schools still decide most of the phone rules for breaks.

○ Trust ○ Control

21 Choose the best rebuttal.

Choose one answer.

1 Control says: "Scores fell, so trust failed."

○ **A** Trust is always perfect.
○ **B** Scores fell in most countries, and the data do not show that trust is the cause.
○ **C** Scores do not matter.

2 Trust says: "An inspector sees only one hour of a teacher's work."

○ **A** Independent data covers all pupils, not one hour in one classroom.
○ **B** Inspectors are expensive.
○ **C** Teachers are never wrong.

3 Control says: "The phone law shows the state does not trust pupils."

○ **A** Pupils are always responsible.
○ **B** Phones do not distract anyone.
○ **C** A limit can support learning, and schools still decide the details.

22 Prepare your side.

YOUR TURN

Our claim _____

Evidence 1 _____

Evidence 2 _____

The other side will say _____

We will reply _____

23 After the debate, write 100 to 130 words.

YOUR TURN

Which side was more convincing, and what is your own view now? Use one concession chunk: It is true that..., but...

END

Quick reference and self-check

Language for the debate

USE	SAY
Claim	Our main point is that… · We believe that…
Evidence	The data show that… · According to the text…
Rebuttal	I see your point, but… · That depends on… · That does not prove that…
Concession	It is true that…, but…
Closing	To sum up… · What worries me is…

Self-check

☐	I can explain in two sentences how Finland trained and trusted its teachers.
☐	I can give two facts that show Finland’s results fell, and one reason why that does not settle the debate.
☐	I can say what the phone law does and what it leaves to schools.
☐	I can defend Trust and Control, even if I disagree with one of them.
☐	I can answer another person’s argument without ignoring it.

The four voices in Document D are invented. Facts come from the sources listed under each document.